

Chapter

The Power of Healing — The Belief That Heals



Introduction: Belief Before Medicine

We assume that illness is cured by medicine. But is it medicine alone that heals? In this discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji uses two well-known effects from modern medical science — the **placebo effect** and the **nocebo effect** — to show that at the root of every cure another power is at work: **belief**.

"So whatever the healing may be, in the language of healing it is called the placebo effect. There are two — one is the placebo effect, the other is the nocebo effect."

1. The Village Doctor and the Story of the Needle

To explain the placebo effect, Acharya Ji recounts the experience of a medical doctor who had gone to a village:

"He gave the people there medicine for a minor illness — he must have given a tablet. At once they raised an uproar in the village: 'A bad doctor has come, he has come to kill us!'"

What was the villagers' complaint?

"'Arre, he didn't put in a needle, he didn't prick us with a needle!' So what is their understanding? The correct medicine is the one given by injection. If he didn't give an injection, then the doctor himself is bad."

Then his senior doctor found a simple solution:

"'What is there to take tension about?' They came up with a very good idea — they gave an injection of distilled water."

And the result?

"By doing this the doctor also became excellent, and the patient got healed too. Do you know why it happened? His faith. It is distilled water; he does not know that. Not the medicine — when a needle is given, you get well. That is his belief."

Distilled water is plain pure water containing no medicine at all. Yet the patient recovered — because he believed.

2. The Three Pillars of Belief

Acharya Ji gives the essence of this story in one sentence:

"That belief heals. Remember just this much: your belief in the doctor, belief in your own self, and belief in medicine."

Healing needs three beliefs:

- **Belief in the doctor**
- **Belief in your own self**
- **Belief in the medicine**

It is not necessary to know the name of the medicine, but it is necessary to trust that it will work:

"You don't even know the name of the medicine, but 'what I am taking will make it happen' — if this is missing, then the treatment does not work either. Most often the patient gives up the hope."

3. The Science of Self-Confidence

Acharya Ji explains that this is not superstition but part of medical training:

"So self-confidence, the science of **atmavishwas** — the doctor is taught that you should develop the placebo effect in your patients. It comes in your medical ethics, you have to build that."

But this belief must first be within the doctor:

"That placebo effect should come to him himself. If you yourself don't believe, it will not come at all."

One who does not believe cannot awaken belief in others.

4. Nocebo: The Poison of Disbelief

The opposite of placebo is nocebo — when disbelief renders even the best medicine useless:

"I am taking the medicine because you are telling me to' — this will not have much effect. The nocebo effect will happen at once; the negative one will happen, not the positive one."

"Nocebo means — I gave you even the best medicine, but you said, 'No, this can't work,' so it will not work. Gradually its effect will keep decreasing, decreasing, decreasing. It is called the nocebo effect."

Medicine taken half-heartedly does not work even halfway; disbelief itself becomes a disease.

5. Shraddha: One Doctor, One Guru

In our own language, this power is called **atmavishwas** (self-confidence) and **shraddha**:

"So in our own language it is called **atmavishwas** — your faith, your **shraddha**. This is the absolute truth."

Shraddha means complete trust and a spirit of surrender. Acharya Ji explains that repeatedly changing one's opinion shows a lack of shraddha — whether with a doctor or a guru:

"'I take four opinions, four doctors' — it means there is no shraddha in the first one. 'I act after asking four gurus' — it means there is no shraddha in the first one."

His direct guidance:

"Choose the first one so well that you can surrender to him completely."

6. The Era of the Family Doctor

Acharya Ji recalls the family doctor of 40–50 years ago, who was a member of the family itself:

"The doctor's name wasn't the main thing at all — Doctor Sharma, Doctor Verma, none of that existed. Doctor **Kaka**, Doctor **Mama**, 'Doctor **Chacha** has come.' So they were like family members."

"They would come home, chat — 'So, how is it going, what's going on?' — and while chatting he might even pop two pills into your mouth — 'Here, take this, you're fine.' So why did this happen? 'He gave it, which means it's done.'"

Half the power of healing lay in that relationship itself — because there was complete trust.

7. Today's Problem: No Trust in Anyone

Today the situation has changed:

"So what is it now? The patient looks everything up on Google himself, so he tries to do half his treatment on his own. So there is no trust in anyone — that's the problem. That is why the placebo effect is decreasing."

Information has increased, but trust has decreased — and with it, the inner power of healing.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 Belief heals** — "That belief heals." Even an injection of distilled water can cure a patient, if he believes.
- 2 The three pillars of belief** — belief in the doctor, in yourself, and in the medicine.
- 3 Placebo and nocebo** — belief makes even a simple remedy effective; disbelief renders even the best medicine useless.
- 4 Belief must first be in the giver** — only when the doctor himself believes can he awaken the placebo effect in the patient.

- 5 **Shraddha and surrender** — asking four doctors or four gurus is a lack of shraddha; choose the first one so that you can surrender to him completely.
- 6 **Today's challenge** — the tendency to do half one's treatment oneself through Google has reduced trust, and with it the power of healing.

The greatest power of healing lies not in the medicine outside, but in the belief within.